

AFP

THE THIRD POLE
NPP alliance presidential candidate and JVP leader Anura Kumara Dissanayake

the planks of ushering radical change, curbing corruption and improving the standard of living. Premadasa says, "We don't believe either in the extreme right-wing, neo-liberal economic liberal policies that have resulted in crony capitalism or the extreme left-wing socialistic way. We will provide a middle of the road vision." (*see Face-Off*)

On the other hand, Dissanayake believes in sweeping state reforms, including a new constitution, to promote national unity and reconciliation. His NPP is seen as forging a Centre-Left social democratic alliance and he is likely to get much of the *aragalaya* support. Harini Amarasuriya, an NPP ideologue and MP, says, "Sri Lanka collapsed because of bad management and corruption caused by the elite capture of power. Our economy is built on a precarious foundation; we are import-dependent, with manufacturing almost having disappeared. We believe the state should determine policy and intervene strategically to harness the country's natural resources. We will bring about a new model of governance that would deepen democracy and democratic participation and help the disadvantaged."

If no candidate gets a majority, it may result in a weak president unable to navigate the treacherous economic waters

The contest remains close, with opinion polls showing that over 30 per cent of the voters are undecided. In Sri Lanka, the president is elected directly; to win, a candidate needs more than 50 per cent of the popular vote. If there's no clear winner, the system provides for second and third preference votes to decide the matter. The fear is that if no candidate gets a clear majority, it could result in a weak president who may find it difficult to navigate the treacherous economic waters. India, which is keen that Sri Lanka remains stable, is watching the outcome with bated breath. ■

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Archrivals Ranil Wickremesinghe, *President of Sri Lanka*, and Sajith Premadasa, *Leader of the Opposition*, are among the frontrunners for the crucial presidential election on Sept. 21. In separate interviews, the two candidates speak to *India Today Group Editorial Director* Raj Chengappa on the importance of the upcoming election, the key issues and concerns, their individual political, economic and social visions, and how they see relations with India progress. Excerpts:

"IT'S A MAKE OR BREAK ELECTION"

RANIL WICKREMESINGHE



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